GLASS ACT

SulaFest is back post-pandemic with an entirely Indian line-up of musicians

Of all the multi-genre, mainstream music festivals that went on hiatus during the pandemic, SulaFest has taken the longest to return. The two-day event organised by and held at Sula Vineyards in Nashik will be staged after a five-year break in 2025, in its usual slot of the first weekend of February.

In the interim, not only has there been an exponential increase in the number of large-scale concerts and music festivals across the country, the purpose for which SulaFest was conceptualised has also been fulfilled. It was launched in 2008 with the aim of drawing people to Sula Vineyards and introducing them to its wines. Their head of hospitality Monit Dhavale says that over the last half-decade, the number of visitors has doubled from more than 200,000 a year to around 400,000 annually.

They're bringing SulaFest back then, owing to public demand. "The idea behind this festival is not commercial gain, but to popularise wine as a beverage," says Dhavale. They considered holding it in 2023, but Sula Vineyards, the company, launched its IPO in December 2022, which took up "all our efforts". Further delays were caused by expansions of its three properties, which include York Winery in Nashik and Domaine Sula near Bengaluru.

This time around, SulaFest–which was hailed for being the first to get to India international acts such as Young The Giant (2015), Jungle (2019) and Bloc Party (2017)–will host an entirely local line-up. The bill, headlined by rapper DIVINE and electronic musicians Ritviz and Karan Kanchan, also features DJ-producer Dualist Inquiry, rock bands Parvaaz and When Chai Met Toast, pop duos Madboy/Mink and OAFF and Savera, and singer/songwriters Ankur Tewari, Aarifah and Frizzell D'Souza.

Other changes include making SulaFest a biennial event and dropping spirits from the offerings (Sula used to import them but has exited the segment). Beer and cocktails remain on the menu while cheese- and chocolate-paired wine tastings and grape stomping will make up the adjacent activities. The 'Atmasphere' electronic music stage will be missing as its erstwhile venue has been converted into a selfie-friendly garden.

> Along with the music, **BEER AND COCKTAILS** remain on the menu, with cheese- and chocolate-paired wine tastings

Though these changes might disappoint some, Dhavale says "a lot depends on how this edition goes" with a plan to "have a good blend of international and national artists and eventually add a second stage". The response has been very encouraging with tickets being bought faster than ever before. "Usually, 30-40 per cent of the sales happen in the last 8-10 days [prior to the event]," says Dhavale. "We're almost sold out already." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

SulaFest is taking place on February 1 and 2 at Sula Vineyards, Nashik

